Northgate Insurance

Claims Handling Procedure - Personal Lines

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This procedure sets out how Northgate claims handlers manage personal lines claims from first notification to settlement. It applies to home, motor and travel claims. Internal use only.

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1. Service standards

Stage	Standard
Acknowledge new claim	Within 1 working day of notification
First contact with the customer	Within 2 working days
Set initial reserve	Within 5 working days
Review open claims	At least every 30 days
Payment after settlement agreed	Within 5 working days

2. First notification of loss (FNOL)

At first notification, the handler must confirm the policy was in force on the date of loss, check the cover section applies, and record the circumstances in the customer's own words.

- Confirm identity and policy number.
- Record date, time and location of the incident.
- Capture a crime reference number for theft or malicious damage.
- Ask whether any other insurance policy may cover the same loss.
- Advise the customer of the excess that applies.

3. Authority levels and referrals

Claim value	Who can authorise
Up to £10,000	Claims handler
£10,001 to £50,000	Senior claims handler
Over £50,000	Technical claims manager

Any claim involving a suspected fraud indicator must be referred to the Counter Fraud Unit, regardless of value.

4. Appointing a loss adjuster

A loss adjuster must be appointed for all subsidence claims, all buildings claims with an estimated value over £7,500, and any contents claim over £15,000. The adjuster should visit within 5 working days of appointment.

5. Fraud indicators

Handlers should look for the following indicators and refer to the Counter Fraud Unit if two or more are present, or if any single indicator is serious.

- Claim made shortly after the policy started or cover was increased.
- Customer is reluctant to provide documents or keeps changing their account.
- Receipts or valuations appear altered or come from unverifiable sources.
- Several recent claims on this or previous policies.
- Items claimed do not match the customer's described lifestyle or home.

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6. Vulnerable customers

If a customer shows signs of vulnerability, such as bereavement, serious illness or financial difficulty, record this with their consent, adapt communication to their needs, and consider a dedicated handler. Do not close a vulnerable customer's claim without a final phone call.

7. Settlement

Settlement may be by repair through a network supplier, replacement through our replacement partner, or cash payment. Where we could repair or replace through a supplier but the customer chooses cash, we may limit the payment to the amount it would have cost us. Always deduct the applicable excess.

8. Declining a claim

A claim may only be declined by a senior claims handler or above. The decline letter must quote the exact policy wording relied on, explain the reason in plain English, and tell the customer about their right to complain and to refer to the Financial Ombudsman Service.

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